Given these obstacles, IOs typically engage in information sharing when faced with significant threats, such as the rise of populist leaders in powerful member states. These leaders often curtail information flows, forcing IOs to seek alternative sources to maintain operational effectiveness. For instance, the United States, a dominant stakeholder in many development IOs, exerts substantial influence over their policies. Under a populist leader like Donald Trump, IOs may lose critical data streams, prompting them to seek new partnerships to mitigate the impact.

Ultimately, information sharing is a vital tool for IOs to navigate populist challenges and maintain their functionality. By pooling resources and expertise, IOs can mitigate the effects of data withholding, safeguard their missions, and reinforce the broader architecture of global governance. This interconnectedness strengthens their ability to address complex global issues, ensuring that international cooperation continues to thrive even in the face of adversity.

4.3 Testing Alternative IO Information Acquisition

We examine the strategies that IOs employ to navigate information shortfalls in the development space, a domain particularly suited to studying information-sharing dynamics. Development IOs often engage in formalized agreements to exchange data, which are publicly documented and therefore conducive to empirical analysis.

We define information sharing as the structured exchange of knowledge between organizations, as formalized through agreements such as memorandums of understanding. These arrangements typically outline specific areas for collaboration, as seen in the 2018 agreement between the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (AIIB) and the Eurasian Development Bank (EDB), which aimed to enhance the “exchange of information and promotion of knowledge-sharing to benefit from each other’s experience, resources, and expertise. Potential areas for information sharing may include: (i) economic, financial and business information on common areas of interest; (ii) information with respect to processing of potential projects for co-financing; and (iii) information in relation to mitigation and management of risks, arising from the co-financing of projects.”[12]